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Off the Record

What your feed won't tell you

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BREAKING ANALYSIS

Hegseth and Rubio Reach for the Nuremberg Playbook

Two cabinet secretaries, one defence: it was the boss's call.

WASHINGTON — At his first press conference in six months, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said the Iran, Maduro, Yemen and boat-strike operations were each **"a lawful operation ordered by the commander-in-chief, then ordered by myself."** Hours later, Marco Rubio told reporters in Paris: **"Ultimately our job is to execute on the president's orders."** It came a day after Republican Rep. **Thomas Massie** filed **articles of impeachment** against Hegseth. The first House procedural vote is due today, and Trump says he stands by his man. Critics supplied the Nuremberg comparison. *"I was just following orders" is a fascist regime's favourite argument. The Department of War (former Fox News house) and the most powerful secretary of state since Kissinger are leaning on it.*

Foreign Affairs

OPINION

Trump May Be Out Faster Than the Voters Can Do It. Enter Vance, Technocrat-in-Chief

MAGA is cracking, and the successor is already warming up.

WASHINGTON — After the midterm shellacking, Trump's approval is in the **low 30s**, and the Guardian reports the MAGA coalition is fracturing, giving Republicans **"a permission structure"** to move away from him. **JD Vance** responded with an essay on X blaming Trump's **unpopular Iran war** for the defeat. *I'm hearing rumblings of a coup inside MAGA. Expect the antichrist, I mean JD Vance, to take up the mantle and fulfil his purpose as a technocratic, end-times-bringing puppet.*

★ EDITOR'S PICK ANALYSIS

US Intelligence Knew. Why Tell Everyone Now?

A honey pot, a chip buyer and $4.8B of Nvidia GPUs.

SANTA CLARA, CA — Nvidia's board is investigating after CEO **Jensen Huang** admitted an affair with **Alice Huang**, a chip buyer and executive at Singapore-based **Megaspeed** whom **US intelligence determined was gathering information for Beijing** (NYT, via AP). Megaspeed bought **$4.8B** of Nvidia chips in two years. The board says it has **"no reason to believe"** secrets were compromised, and China calls it a smear campaign. *A honey pot? US intel never seems to wanna share, so why now? How long did they know? I suspect Washington is using the story to get a look inside China's closed manufacturing industry.*

ANALYSIS

The Deadliest War Since WWII Isn't on Your Feed

Six million dead, and the world scrolls on.

KINSHASA — Decades of conflict in the Democratic Republic of Congo, including the ongoing **M23 rebellion** in mineral-rich North Kivu, have left an estimated **6 million dead**. The Great African War and its offshoots rarely trend. *Largest conflict in the world, no one cares, and it's to your benefit.*

ANALYSIS

From Allies to Enemies: The Next African War Has Already Started

Eritrean troops are reportedly inside Tigray, and Ethiopia wants the sea.

ASMARA — The two fought side by side in the **2020–22 Tigray war** that killed **hundreds of thousands**. Since a rebel alliance attacked on **Sept 23**, Eritrean forces are alleged to have pushed up to **60 km** into Tigray. Ethiopia is demanding Red Sea access, and Eritrea fears it means the port of **Assab**. Ethiopian online influencers are already pushing "now or never." *More wars in Africa you haven't heard of, and the numbers are about to climb.*

OPINION

Your Fridge Is Now a Front Line

Hackers cooked Europe's freezers. I did say more cyber attacks.

LONDON — Supermarket fridges and freezers across **seven European countries** climbed to as high as **50°C** after a suspected attack on the companies that run their controllers. Kyiv got a **fake nuclear alert** through a hacked emergency app on Nov 1, French blood banks were hit, and Vanderbilt University is in a ransomware incident. The UK's cyber chief says we're in the **"foothills"** of a new hacking landscape. *Everything with a Wi-Fi chip is a target, and the old stuff nobody patches is first in line.*

Bread and Circuses

GUEST OPINION

Bread and Circuses: Jacobs' Broken Finger Does What the NFL Won't

Coincidence or foreshadowing?

Guest writer: Blaise

GREEN BAY, WI — Packers running back **Josh Jacobs** was cleared in **Week 7** while the NFL's conduct investigation into domestic-violence **allegations** was still open, and a suspension is still possible. Then he fractured the **ring finger on his right hand** against the Patriots after **four carries**. He needs **surgery this week** and could miss up to **three weeks**, or land on injured reserve. *The injury has nothing to do with the allegations, but the timing is hard to ignore.*

Last Week's Call

Mississippi goes blue
Democrat Scott Colom leads Sen. Cindy Hyde-Smith, the ballot-counting deadline has passed, and Mississippi has no automatic recount. The AP hasn't formally called it. If it holds, he's the **first Black senator from Mississippi since Reconstruction**. *I said it would go blue eventually. It's essentially over.*

More cyber attacks
Frozen-food freezers cooked across Europe, a **fake nuclear alert in Kyiv**, hacked blood banks and Vanderbilt held to ransom. *And it's only the foothills.*

HEARD IN THE GROUP CHAT

Blaise
sorry cam i can't help but notice you forgot to include an article about bryce hall getting into a fight

I fear thermonuclear war drums and Canada's entire GdP worth of losses in the s&p overshadowed that this week

— *C.*